

Beneath the Mulberry Tree

By Mursal Nader

The plane door closed behind me, and just like that, I was leaving Kabul – and generations of expectation, tradition, and whispered warnings. But I carried something heavier. Stronger. The weight of my father's belief in me.

It wasn't me they questioned. It was him. "How could you send your daughter so far, alone, to a land we barely know." They murmured over steaming cups of tea, in judgement wrapped in concern. Some said it out loud. Others held their silence like a verdict, their eyes telling a story of disbelief – that I was reaching places they never thought possible.

My father, a man who rises with the first call to prayer – not out of ritual, but conviction – stood firm. "Our prophet, peace be upon him, said, 'Seeking knowledge is obligatory on every Muslim man and woman'". He didn't raise his voice. He didn't need to. He remained grounded in his faith. My father's deep religiosity was never at odds with my ambition – it was the reason for it. He never treated me any differently from my brothers because the pursuit of knowledge transcended gender in his eyes. That conviction wasn't learned from books; it was learned from blood.

My grandfather was a farmer with rough, calloused hands from years of hard labor in the fields. He had no formal education, but was determined that his son would have a better life. When relatives stopped my father from going to school, my grandfather physically fought them. He wrestled his own cousins to the ground so that his son might one day hold a pen instead of a plow. "Why waste time?" They asked. "He should be working in the fields." My grandfather knew that the power of education surpassed the pull of tradition. Thus, he stood between his son and ignorance, and my father fulfilled that vision by becoming a doctor.

Years later, when most men in their fifties were preparing for retirement, my father surprised everyone by enrolling in an online master's program in clinical psychology. He had nothing left to prove, but he did it anyway because learning was a form of worship to him.

That legacy of defiance and belief, passed down through generations, shaped my father – and now, it's shaping me. When it was my turn to leave, my father stood his ground just like his father had once done for him.

I remember something he told me weeks before I left:

"I worked alongside doctors from the UK, Japan, Canada – my training was equal, my knowledge the same. But because my degree was from Afghanistan, the world wouldn't recognize it."

He paused, then looked at me. "I want you to have what I didn't – the freedom to work anywhere in the world." That stayed with me. He wasn't just sending me abroad for an education – he was setting me free to become someone the world had never prepared for.

At sixteen, I was daring to dream of a future that hadn't been written for me, but one I could write. So, I went. Not with certainty or guarantees, but with courage and grit. I carried more than luggage – I carried my father's faith in me. Belief, I've learned, is the most powerful gift you can receive because when someone believes in you without condition, you begin to believe in yourself even when the world tells you not to.

That was my fight, not against a single person, but against the quiet systems that teach girls they were never meant to fly. Just like my grandfather once fought for a boy's right to hold a pen, my father fought for my right to use mine.

The morning I left Kabul, the air felt heavy like the kind of heaviness that comes before a moment you can't take back. At the airport, I kissed my parents' hands – a gesture of respect, and goodbye in Afghan culture. My mother's skin smelled faintly of rose lotion. My father – always one to reject the hierarchy the gesture implied – gently pulled his hands away. I pretended to be strong even as tears ran down my face. My mother pulled me into a tight embrace and said, "Khuda hafiz, bachem. Khuda posht-o panahet." Goodbye, my child. May God bless you.

My father, always the one to soften a hard moment, smiled and said, "Don't fret, Qahraman 'champion'! It's only for a year like the fleeting wind. Before you know it, you'll be home again." Little did he know it would take me eleven years to visit home.

As the plane ascended, I watched the jagged peaks of Hindu Kush mountains fade beneath my window, but the memories of Kabul stayed with me. I could still breathe the cool morning air from our patio, filled with the fragrance of blooming flowers, the sweetness of grapes hanging from the vines, and the warm, comforting aroma of fresh naan. Wrapped in those memories, I felt a sense of peace and wholeness. I carried Kabul with me.

Leaving Kabul was just the beginning of a journey that would teach me how to speak – not just in words, but with courage. In eleventh grade, I left Afghanistan through the prestigious, highly competitive Youth Exchange & Study (YES) program, funded by the U.S. Department of State. I arrived in a small American town and enrolled at Chatham Public High School, where I completed New York State Regents diploma requirements in a year. Graduating with a Regents diploma meant little back home, but symbolized everything to me: the fact that I belonged in a classroom anywhere in the world.

As part of the YES program, I took on the role of an ambassador for Afghanistan, sharing my country's rich culture and the resilience of its people, especially women at local public schools, cultural events, and community gatherings. In addition, I shared my personal journey and advocated for women's right to education as the key to creating meaningful and lasting change in the world.

I was often told that I was a natural public speaker. Watching my audience's perception of Afghanistan change filled me with energy and hope. Through my voice, I was building bridges of understanding and dialogue between nations. So, I sought to replace narrow media narratives with authentic stories from Afghanistan, especially those highlighting the lives of Afghan women.

During my first year in the U.S., I discovered the transformative power of critical thinking skill, which is rarely emphasized in Afghanistan's education system. This discovery inspired me to apply for an additional year of study at Hawthorne Valley Waldorf School, a private institution that encourages curiosity and open inquiry over the pursuit of “right” answers. The Waldorf curriculum challenged me to rethink and relearn as I grappled with profound questions about identity and purpose: *What is identity? Who are we beyond the constraints of societal expectation?* Waldorf's holistic approach taught me that true strength comes from fully embracing one's identity. I began to recognize my voice as a core part of who I was becoming, and I was ready to bring that voice to a place where it could truly thrive – Smith College.

Getting into Smith wasn't easy. It's one of the most selective liberal arts colleges in the United States with a proud legacy of championing women's education and leadership. Being accepted wasn't just a personal achievement – it was a milestone for the generations of women in my family who had been denied the chance to pursue their dreams. While many believed my time abroad would be brief, I was determined to rewrite that narrative. I pushed past expectations, worked harder than anyone knew, and went to college. Yet, crossing that threshold was only the beginning.

At Smith, I found my voice – the one my father always said was my greatest strength, even when I hadn't found it yet. Not the voice I used to raise my hand in class, hoping for the right answer, but the voice that rose to say: *This isn't right. This has to change.*

In Afghanistan, girls rarely get the chance to discover their voice, not due to a lack of will, but because they're silenced before they ever have the opportunity. The Taliban don't just fear women with books, they fear women with thoughts. So, they ban education because the surest way to keep someone powerless is to keep her ignorant. My father used to say: “Education doesn't just lift you out of poverty, it frees you from ignorance.” He believed ignorance was the root of every kind of oppression and he wasn't wrong.

At Smith, I saw the truth of that – not just in lectures, but in how my world grew wider with every book, every discussion, every idea that challenged what I thought I knew. In the process of unlearning and relearning, I discovered the voice that had always been within me. I began to speak – for the girls back home, and for myself – because once you find your voice, there's no returning to silence. That voice became my driving force. Today, I am pursuing my Ph.D. in science at the University of Toronto – a journey that requires hard work, determination, and resilience.

There were times when I felt like giving up and called home in tears. One night stands out. My experiment had failed twice, producing inconsistent results. I felt trapped. My brilliant friends were celebrating their breakthroughs while I felt like I had nothing to show. It appeared as though everyone else was moving forward, and I was stuck in place.

I stared at the results, struggling to make sense of anything. I began to question myself: What am I doing here? I had already switched projects once during my PhD due to inconsistent results. Maybe science wasn't for me. This self-doubt wasn't simply due to a failed experiment, but the gnawing fear that I didn't belong. That's when I called home to hear the voice that always made everything feel possible.

The phone rang once, twice. Then my father's voice, steady as ever "Assalamu Alaikum, Qahraman." Just hearing that word – Qahraman (champion) – relaxed something in my chest, but I still couldn't speak. When I finally admitted that I thought I was not good enough, he listened. "You're trying to climb the mountain all at once", he said. "But even the highest peak in the Hindu Kush mountain range is conquered one step at a time." He continued, "You take one step. Then, another. You break everything down into small tasks and then act."

I stayed silent. "Success," he continued, "needs two things: *tasmem aw amal* – decision and action. Without both, nothing happens. President Mohammad Dawood Khan – the first president of Afghanistan, a leader known for his progressive policies and efforts to improve women's rights – once said, '*Tasmem da bri lumri shart di*,' meaning, 'Decision is the first condition for success.' But I tell you – *tasmem* and *amal* are both necessary."

My father admired Dawood Khan's vision for a modern Afghanistan, one where education and progress took precedence over tradition. Yet today, it's ironic. The very plans that Dawood Khan initiated to modernize Afghanistan – roads, mapping, infrastructure – are being used by the Taliban without acknowledgement.

As much as history shifts, my father's words remind me that true progress depends not just on the decision to act, but on the actions that carry the vision forward. I am now carrying forward a vision that spans generations – a vision that refuses to be silenced. I didn't reach the summit that night, but the mountain didn't feel as daunting anymore. In that stillness, I discovered something deeper. I remembered where my story began. Not in a laboratory or a classroom, but in the soil of my homeland – beneath a mulberry tree.

On one visit back to Afghanistan, I sat with my grandmother beneath the mulberry tree – *shahtoot*, 'the king of berries,' as we call it – in her courtyard. We were sipping black tea with cardamom when she told me of a distant relative who had taken a second wife. I asked, "Did the first wife agree?" My grandmother looked at me with surprise, almost amusement. "No, child. She didn't even know until after it happened." I felt heat rise to my face. "Then she should divorce him." She paused holding a vintage bone china teacup halfway to her lips. "She can't" she said, "but I knew you'd say that." I blinked. "Why?" She gave me a long, quiet look. Then said something I will never forget: "Because you're already independent – something she can only dream of." It wasn't envy, it was tenderness – the weight of a life lived in silence, compromise, and obedience.

In that moment, I realized that education had not just given me knowledge, it had given me options. It had given me the courage to say no – not only to people, but to injustice itself. My grandmother's life was shaped by decisions made for her, while I now lived in a world where I could shape my own future. That difference – that simple, profound shift – was the quiet revolution education had given me.

I come from men who fought so I can have choices my mother and grandmother never did. My grandfather gave my father a future; my father gave me the right to shape mine. But the seed of that future was planted long before me by an illiterate farmer who fought for education, by the quiet strength of women who endured, and through a legacy passed down across generations.

Even now, when women's voices are too often silenced around the world, I think of the mulberry tree – steadfast, growing, and quietly defiant. Its roots remind me that my story is anchored in the strength of those who came before me while its seeds remind me to carry that strength forward by planting them wherever I go.

The story isn't over. This is the part where I write it – with the pen my grandfather once dreamed of, the freedom my father made possible, and the voice I discovered beneath the mulberry tree.

End